



Battle of the homeboys: USA's Frances Tiafoe was trying to become the first Black American to reach the US Open final since Arthur Ashe in 1972 but was stopped in his tracks by Fritz in the semifinal. REUTERS

sports-crazy metropolis.

Tiafoe, a muscle-flexing showman whose father is an immigrant from Sierra Leone, revels in the raucous night atmosphere at Arthur Ashe Stadium. Who would win the all-American semifinal? "It's going to be the guy who is aggressive and doesn't blink at the biggest moments," Tiafoe predicted.

Fritz learned the hard way that talk is cheap. "I came into this tournament in 2022 saying I thought I could win it, and I lost in the first round. So, I think it's good to just take it one match at a time and focus on the person in front of you."

'Big Foe' was trying to become the first Black American to reach the US

Open final since Arthur Ashe in 1972. On a roll, he had won 10 of his last 11 matches, succumbing only to Sinner in Cincinnati.

But Fritz had taken their last six contests, which made him a 61 per cent favourite, according to IBM Match Insights. "If Tiafoe can make it a more athletic match than a ball-striking one, he can win," said Patrick McEnroe.

A courtside ticket sold for \$8,000 for this much-anticipated clash, attracting the likes of Bam Adebayo, Klay Thompson, Kevin Garnett, musician Fat Joe, golfer Rory McIlroy, soccer legend Megan Rapinoe, and actress Da'Vine Joy Randolph, among other celebrities.

For four sets, the duel between the Davis Cup teammates lived up to expectations. Fritz's improved court coverage and conditioning surprised Tiafoe, who in turn surprised his opponent with high-powered yet consistent groundstrokes.

Buoyed by the crowd, Tiafoe

grabbed the opening set 6-4. But Fritz played a sensational game at 6-5 in the second to break at love with a nifty backhand volley he sharply angled for a winner. That evened the match at a set apiece. When Tiafoe played the big points better to capture the third set 6-4, his hometown supporters watching on TV at the JTCC Watch Park in College Park, Maryland, exulted.

Serving at 3-all, 30-15, a gruelling 31-shot exchange wore out Tiafoe, who didn't run for Fritz's forehand crosscourt winner.

The pressure of a must-hold game at 4-5 got to Tiafoe after he built a 40-15 lead. Two double faults, a shanked forehand, and a poor forehand drop shot into the net due to a brain cramp cost him the fourth set 6-4.

Much fresher than his weary foe, Fritz broke serve three times and finished off Big Foe with an ace for a 4-6, 7-5, 4-6, 6-4, 6-1 triumph.

"The question will be, how much